

Do You Run Out of Money Before You Run Out of Month?

- I'd give up my maid service, but I don't have time to clean.
- I'd give up smoking, but then I'll gain weight.
- I'd give up manicures, but I need to look professional for my job.
- I'd give up the nanny, but what would the neighbors think?

These excuses and a million more can justify almost any expense remaining intact.

At the end of the session the counselor looked at the couple and said, "If you leave here today and do not change anything in your lifestyle, you will be broke in three weeks." This shocking realization silenced Anita and Tom. The counselor was convinced she would never hear from them again since they were so steadfast in their beliefs. She was surprised when they called her about a month later.

After they were forced to confront the reality of their situation, they started to make some very difficult adjustments. Anita closed down her gallery temporarily and sub-leased it to another business, the nanny was referred to one of their neighbors, and Anita actually enjoyed playing mom! Their neighbors were envious that Anita was raising her kids without needing any help. Tom even had a property in escrow, and for the first time in a year they saw their financial situation improving.

Tom and Anita were stuck in the "keeping up with the Joneses" trap. All their neighbors seemed to have a nanny, drive expensive cars, own beautiful homes, and send their children to private schools. It takes courage to break out of this mold.

Tom and Anita made the discovery that the downsizing of their lifestyle didn't result in any lost friendships. All of their

